

WORKING AT HEIGHT TOOLBOX TALK

Prevent falls, falling objects and fatal injuries.

8-10 MINUTES

OBJECTIVE

Review fall, falling-object, unsafe-access and rescue hazards associated with working at height, and verify that all required protective measures are in place before the task begins.

TOPIC EXPLANATION

- Working at height is not limited to very tall structures. Platforms, scaffolds, ladders, roofs, openings and equipment surfaces are included whenever a person could fall from one level to another and suffer injury.
- Falls commonly involve unprotected edges, open floor penetrations, unsafe access, defective equipment or incorrect use of fall-protection systems. Dropped tools and materials can also cause fatal injuries to people working below.
- Work must begin only when the permit, risk assessment, safe access, inspected equipment and a practical rescue plan are available. Collective protection such as guardrails and working platforms must be considered before personal fall-arrest systems.

REALISTIC SITE SCENARIO

- A worker leaned outside a platform guardrail to complete a short connection task. Because the job was expected to take only a few minutes, a suitable working platform was not installed.
- The worker wore a harness, but the connecting hook was not attached to an approved anchor point. When balance was lost, no effective system was available to arrest the fall.
- The event could have been completely prevented by providing a suitable platform, maintaining the guardrails, using an approved anchor and completing a supervisor check before starting.

REMEMBER

Wearing a harness is not enough. Correct anchorage, a suitable connecting system, adequate fall clearance and a ready rescue plan must all be provided.

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Hazards, control measures and daily pre-work verification.

8-10 MINUTES

KEY HAZARDS

- Falls from unprotected edges or working platforms.
- Open floor penetrations, access openings and trapdoors.
- Unsuitable ladders, scaffolds or working platforms.
- Damaged or incorrectly used harnesses and lanyards.
- Unapproved or inadequate anchor points.
- Tools, equipment or materials falling to lower levels.
- Adverse weather, slippery surfaces or poor lighting.
- Suspension after a fall and inadequate rescue preparation.

CONTROL MEASURES

- Verify the approved permit and risk assessment.
- Use guardrails, platforms and covers as the first priority.
- Confirm inspection of scaffolds, ladders and access equipment.
- Inspect the full-body harness and connecting system.
- Use only approved and adequately rated anchor points.
- Secure tools and barricade the area below.
- Assess weather, surface and lighting conditions.
- Check fall clearance and swing-fall exposure.
- Provide competent supervision and communication.
- Keep a practical rescue plan and equipment ready.

SUPERVISOR TALKING SCRIPT

Team, today's work at height can become a fatal fall after one small loss of balance. We will not start until guardrails, access, the working platform and the anchor point have been checked. Simply wearing a harness is not enough; the worker must remain correctly connected. If conditions change, we will stop and reassess the work. Everyone must understand how rescue will be completed if a fall occurs.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- At what height and in which area will today's work take place?
- Are the guardrails, platform and safe access complete?
- Who approved the anchor point that will be used?
- Have the harness and connecting equipment been inspected?
- How will dropped tools and materials be prevented?
- Who will perform the rescue and how will it be completed?

VERIFY BEFORE STARTING TODAY

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Permit approved | ☐ Risk assessment suitable |
| ☐ Safe access ready | ☐ Guardrails complete |
| ☐ Platform inspected | ☐ Anchor approved |
| ☐ Harness serviceable | ☐ Connection suitable |
| ☐ Lower area barricaded | ☐ Rescue plan ready |

ATTENDANCE AND APPROVAL

WORKING AT HEIGHT TOOLBOX TALK

Project / Site

Date

Presented by

Work area

No	Full Name	Company / Role	Signature
1			
2			
3			
4			
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Supervisor notes / additional site instructions